

A 2026 GUIDE BY YOUR LOCAL HOST

Mongolia in Summer

an honest guide — what's actually worth it, what brochures lie about, and what nobody tells you.

By Tugi

Wild Mongolia with Tugi · wildmongoliatugi.com

CHAPTER ONE

Why I wrote this.

Most Mongolia guides are made by people who came once and left. This one is mine. I grew up here, I host small-group trips here every summer, and I get the same fifty questions from everyone who comes. Instead of typing them out in WhatsApp at 2 a.m., here they are.

This is the country I love, written honestly. Some things in the brochures aren't worth it. Some things nobody tells you about are everything. I'll be specific.

If, after reading this, you want me to take you around — that's at the back. If you just take the guide and go on your own, even better. The country wins either way.

— *Tugi*

CHAPTER TWO

Why summer is the only window.

You'll see “all-season Mongolia” tours. Don't believe them. From November to April this country can hit -40°C and the countryside shuts down. Summer is when:

- The steppe is green.
- Rivers are crossable.
- Families are out at their summer camps, not winter pastures.
- Naadam happens (mid-July).
- Wildflowers are real.

Pick your month

June is gentlest. Cool nights, fewer travellers, water still high. Best for the south.

July is the festival peak — Naadam (11–13) and Playtime around the same week. Energy is the highest.

August has the deepest skies and the warmest lake water. Best for the north and the long expeditions.

Pick by what you want to do, not by who's cheaper.

The five regions, explained.

Mongolia isn't one place. The brochure photos blur four very different countries into one. Here's the actual breakdown.

North — Khövsgöl + the Khentii taiga

Siberian-edge country. Larch forest, the deepest freshwater lake on the continent, reindeer-herder families if you go far enough. Cooler temperatures, water everywhere. **Best for:** people who think “travel” means quiet.

Central — Orkhon, Karakorum, hot springs

The Mongol-empire heartland. Rolling green steppe, working monasteries, hot springs, family ger camps. Easiest to combine with anything else. **Best for:** first-timers who want the postcard.

South — the Gobi

Desert. Singing dunes, ice canyons, dinosaur fossils, camels. Hot and dry by day, cold at night. Long drive days. **Best for:** people who like extremes.

West — Altai Tavan Bogd

The most distinct part of the country. Kazakh, not Mongolian, in feel. Eagle hunters, glacier peaks, Bronze Age petroglyphs. Furthest to get to (you'll fly). **Best for:** serious mountain people.

East — Khan Khentii + Dornod steppe

Less travelled. Big skies, fewer tourists, harder logistics. **Best for:** a second trip, not a first.

CHAPTER FOUR

What's worth it. What isn't.

Cards on the table.

WORTH IT

- Sleeping in a real family ger, not a tourist ger camp.
- One full day in any canyon (Yoliin Am, Orkhon).
- Khorkhog at least once — lamb cooked on hot stones in a sealed pot.
- Camel ride at Khongoriin Els at golden hour. Not midday.
- Watching the kids race horses at any local Naadam.
- The drive itself. Yes, the drive.
- A long soak at Tsenkher hot springs after four nights of camping.
- Stargazing once you're past Dalanzadgad. There is no light to compete.

OVERRATED / SKIP

- Sumo-wrestler-themed restaurants in UB. Gimmick.
- "Genghis Khan brand" anything. Souvenir tax.
- Half-day Terelj tours from UB. You'll feel cheated.
- Mass-tour Naadam in UB's main stadium. Find a village one instead.
- "Eco-luxury" ger camps with WiFi. You came here to disconnect, did you not?
- More than one full day in UB. The country is the country, not the city.

The two festivals.

Naadam — July 11–13

Three sports: horse racing, Mongolian wrestling, archery. The big-stadium version in Ulaanbaatar is for tourists. **Go to a village Naadam** — sub-province (*sum*) level. Small enough that you'll know which kid won the 25 km long-distance horse race. Holiday food everywhere. Costumes are real, not for the cameras.

If you want to combine Naadam with the rest of the country, plan around the date. Travel within Mongolia gets harder in that week — book ahead.

Playtime — early July

Mongolia's main music festival. Held at Playtime Field in Nalaikh, 40 minutes east of UB. International lineup mixed with Mongolian acts. Three days of camping. 20s and 30s crowd, very international — Seoul, Berlin, Melbourne all show up. Cheap relative to European festivals. Good vibes.

If you're festival-curious but not destination-curious, this is also the one weekend Mongolia is suddenly easy.

Ger etiquette — the ten actual rules.

Most guides skim this. Don't. You'll be sleeping in someone's home.

- Enter on the left side (men) or right side (women, kids).
- Never step *on* the threshold. Stride over it.
- Don't whistle inside a ger.
- Don't point at people, the altar, or the ovoo (shrine) with your finger — use your whole hand, palm up.
- Don't refuse offered milk tea (*süütei tsai*). At least take one sip.
- Accept and pass things with the right hand. Both hands is even better.
- Don't lean on the support poles. They're holding the house up.
- Don't photograph the family altar without asking.
- Take your shoes off only if asked. Most families don't.
- If they offer airag (fermented mare's milk), have a small sip. Smile even if it's not your thing. It'll come back later as a story you can tell.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Real summer packing list.

Layers. Mornings can be 5°C, afternoons 28°C — both in the same day.

CORE — don't leave home without

- Hiking boots, broken in. Not new.
- Sleeping bag rated to 0°C, or rent one in UB.
- Down jacket. Even in July.
- Rain shell.
- Sun hat AND warm hat.
- High-UV sunscreen. The sun is fierce at altitude.
- Bug spray (mostly for June).
- Headlamp.
- Power bank, large — 20,000 mAh+.
- Water filter (Lifestraw or Sawyer) or purification tablets.

NICE TO HAVE

- Quick-dry towel.
- Sandals or river shoes — you'll cross water.
- A book. You'll have hours.
- Whatever camera you actually use, not the one you bought.
- One nice top for a final UB dinner.

DON'T BOTHER

- A drone. Regulated. You probably can't fly where you want.
- Heels, jewellery, blow-dryer.
- More than two pairs of jeans.
- Heavy DSLR if you already have a phone you're comfortable with.

Money. Cards. Tipping.

- **Cash:** ATMs in UB and every aimag (province) capital. Outside cities, cash only.
- **Currency:** USD widely accepted in UB tourist places, MNT (tögrög) everywhere else. Take more cash than you think you need.
- **Card outages** happen. Carry a backup.
- **Tipping:** not a traditional Mongolian thing, but expected for tour drivers and guides. \$5–10/day per person is generous.
- Carry small bills. Change is sometimes a problem.

Realistic daily budget (outside cities)

- Solo backpacker, hostel-tier: \$30–50/day.
- Small-group tour: \$90–150/day all-in (food, lodging, transport, guide).
- Self-drive: \$80–120/day before fuel surprises.

Health, altitude, water.

- **Altitude:** rarely an issue. Highest you'll likely be is ~3,000m at the Altai glacier viewpoint.
- **Water:** drink only filtered or bottled water. Boiled in a kettle counts.
- **Insurance:** get travel insurance with evacuation cover. Mongolian distances are real and hospitals are sparse outside UB.
- **Food:** mostly meat-and-flour. Vegetarians can survive but need to tell your guide a week ahead.
- **Most common complaint:** diarrhea. Pack loperamide and ORS sachets. Gloves up.

What to leave at the chemist

- Loperamide / Imodium (diarrhea).
- Oral rehydration salts (ORS).
- Paracetamol.
- Antihistamine (you'll see horses).
- Sunscreen SPF 50.
- Basic plasters + antiseptic wipes.

Connectivity (or lack thereof).

- **4G works** in cities and along the main highways.
- **It does NOT work** past about 80% of where you'll actually go.
- Get a local SIM (Unitel or Mobicom) at the airport. ~\$15 for 30 days, ~10 GB.
- Tell people at home you'll be off-grid for a few stretches. They'll understand. Or they won't — that's on them.

“You won't miss the wifi. You'll miss the people who were ok with you having no wifi.”

Safety — the honest version.

- Crime rate is low. Most travel issues are logistics, not danger.
- Realistic risk: petty theft in UB at night. Pickpockets near the State Department Store and Sukhbaatar Square.
- Avoid empty UB streets after 1 a.m. alone, especially with phone out.
- The country is safe. The wolf encounter you're imagining is not happening.
- If self-driving: animals on the road, big distances between fuel stops, sudden rain that turns dirt roads to mud. Drive slow.
- Always carry a paper map. Phones lose signal and battery; paper doesn't.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Best month for each region.

If you only have a week and want to optimize, here's the cheat sheet.

Region	Sweet spot	Why
North (Khövsgöl)	late July – mid August	lake water warm enough to swim; mosquitos gone
Central	any summer month	the country's most forgiving region
South (Gobi)	early June or late August	mid-July is brutal heat
West (Altai)	July – mid August	snow holds at altitude until early July
East (Khentii)	July only really	short, wet, beautiful window

None of these are wrong months — these are the ideal ones.

How to actually get here.

FLIGHTS

Fly UB (Chinggis Khaan International). Main airlines: **MIAT Mongolian, Aero Mongolia, Korean Air, Turkish, Air China**. Common 1-stop routings: Beijing, Seoul, Istanbul, Hong Kong, Tokyo, Moscow. From Europe, Istanbul is usually the cheapest hop. From the US, Seoul or Beijing.

VISA

30-day visa-free for many passports (US, UK, most EU, AU, NZ, Korea, Japan). Double-check on your country's foreign-affairs website. Bring a passport with 6+ months of validity and at least two blank pages.

THE TRAIN

The Trans-Mongolian (Moscow–UB–Beijing) is great if you have four days and like trains. It is the long way in. Most people fly. Worth doing once in your life, not the right move for a summer trip.

LAST CHAPTER

About me. About the trips.

Hi. I'm Tugi. I grew up traveling Mongolia's countryside with my grandparents. Now I run small-group trips here every summer — 5 to 8 people, June through August, ten departures total. Routes I already know. Families I trust. Prices I'm not ashamed of.

It's not a tour company. It's me, showing you around.

“I don't run this like a business. I run it like hosting cousins from out of town.”

If you want a trip

Go to **wildmongoliatugi.com**. Pick a date. Send the form. I'll reply within 48 hours.

If you don't want a trip but want to ask me something

Email **tuklobin@gmail.com** or DM **@mongoladventure** on Instagram. Free. I read everything.

Either way

Come in summer. Don't believe the brochures.

— Tugi

Ulaanbaatar · written between trips, May 2026

APPENDIX

Quick contact card.

Wild Mongolia with Tugi

Website: wildmongoliatugi.com

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Instagram: [@mongoladventure](https://www.instagram.com/mongoladventure)

2026 tours: 10 departures, June – August, 5–8 people per trip, \$350–\$1,300 per person.

Permission to share this guide

Forward it. Send it to a friend who keeps saying they want to come to Mongolia. Don't resell it. That's all.